[speak with] a very thin or coy voice. [It's because] we don't talk like that [in real life]." For Bagchi, 'Aaj Ki Raat' helped change the perception that she was only interested in rendering classical-leaning material—which was perhaps reinforced when Sanjay Leela Bhansali enlisted her for his 2022 album, *Sukoon*, and subsequently *Heeramandi*.

Bagchi says her career highlights so far include singing for the filmmaker, Trivedi and Sachin-Jigar, with whom she's collaborated the most. Her 2025 release calendar includes more tunes with Sachin-Jigar; a song for the new season of Coke Studio Bharat; and a track for *Bhool Chuk Maaf* composed by Tanishk Bagchi, who, contrary to popular belief, is not a relative. "When I first moved here, somebody asked me, 'He's your brother, why isn't he giving you work?'" ■

—Amit Gurbaxani

SONGS OF FREEDOM

With her debut Hindi song, Afghan singer Aryana Sayeed hopes to reach out to a larger audience

Familial displeasure, death threats, a bounty on her head, Aryana Sayeed had to overcome a number of obstacles on her way to becoming one of Afghanistan's beloved pop stars. "I had basically accepted death," says the 39-year-old musician and activist, who has made her Hindi debut with *Rukhna Nahin*, a song from the recent anthology film, *My Melbourne*. "I felt that if I gave up, I'd be killing the hopes of millions of Afghan women."

Sayeed was just eight when her family fled Afghanistan's civil war to Switzerland, where she fell in love with pop divas like Madonna and Beyoncé (and our very own Alisha Chinai). At 13, she decided she wanted to be a singer. Her conservative Afghan family disagreed, and she had to put those dreams on hold. But in 2008, now an adult living in London, she released her first single *Mashallah*, an English-Farsi-Urdu collaboration with a British-Pakistani guitarist. The song's success convinced her to become a full-time musician.

By 2011, she had built quite a following back home, and one of Afghanistan's biggest TV channels invited her to perform a live concert in Kabul. The concert was a big success, and she was signed on to host her own TV show. Not everyone was on board, though. Threats meant that when she was in Afghanistan, she had to live in the same compound as the TOLO TV studios. When the Taliban retook Kabul in 2021, Sayeed was one of the thousands evacuated by the US. But that traumatic experience hasn't deterred her. She continues to sing. "We love Bollywood, and it's a dream for me to do more Bollywood songs," she says. "I want people in India to know me, my story, and get to hear my voice." ■

—Bhanuj Kappal



BY 2011, ARYANA HAD BUILT QUITE A FAN FOLLOWING AND WAS INVITED TO PERFORM A LIVE CONCERT IN KABUL. ITS SUCCESS LED TO A TV SHOW

"*SABR* IS OUR MOST VULNERABLE OFFERING YET," SAYS AVC FOUNDER AND COMPOSER VARMA

of fate, celebration, love, longing and resilience.

"*Sabr*, our third studio album, is a testament to the silence between the noise—a space where growth, grief and grace coexist. Each track carries a moment of waiting, of learning, of healing. It's our most vulnerable offering yet, and we truly hope it resonates with listeners," says Delhi-based composer and pianist Anirudh Varma, founder and director of AVC.

Founded in 2018, AVC has held over 600 concerts across India and the world, and is recognised for bridging classical traditions with a modern sensibility. The band's debut album, *Perspectives* (2018), with more than 70 artistes collaborating, reimagines Indian classical with jazz, funk and contemporary sounds. This was followed by *Homecoming* (2022), an intimate EP created during the pandemic.

The band is currently planning an India tour to promote *Sabr*, with the first show at NMACC, Mumbai, on May 10, followed possibly by an international tour around the album. "We have also begun working on a set of new songs for our fourth album. The Collective is currently working towards *Kahat Kabir 2.0*, a production dedicated to the music of Kabir Das," says Varma. ■

—Neha Kirpal